

Reliability Ranking Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Cross-AOK • 25-35 min

Category	Cross-AOK	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	reliability-ranking

Big idea: Certainty varies across kinds of knowledge.

Overview

Students compare certainty, usefulness and interpretation across knowledge claims.

Student Prompt

Inspect Reliability Ranking Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Reliability Ranking Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Knowledge claims ranked by certainty, usefulness, and risk if wrong. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Reliability Ranking Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A second ranking after students learn the method behind each claim. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Reliability Ranking Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A discussion on whether reliability means the same thing in every AOK. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Certainty varies across kinds of knowledge.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Reliability Ranking Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Reliability Ranking Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Is certainty the best measure of knowledge?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how certainty varies across kinds of knowledge.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Knowledge claims ranked by certainty, usefulness, and risk if wrong.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Knowledge claims ranked by certainty, usefulness, and risk if wrong.
- A second ranking after students learn the method behind each claim.
- A discussion on whether reliability means the same thing in every AOK.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give cards such as: "The angles in a Euclidean triangle sum to 180 degrees", "Smoking increases lung cancer risk", "This poem expresses grief", "Most people conform under group pressure", "This painting is beautiful".	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students rank claims from most to least certain.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	They then rank from most to least useful.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Compare the two rankings.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may apply one AOK's standard of evidence to all knowledge claims.
- Students may equate certainty with value or usefulness.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Compares standards of evidence across at least two AOKs.
- Explains how a claim changes when method, context, or audience changes.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- What Counts as Evidence?
- Same Object, Different AOK